

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-04-15

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

dear b ahá'í f riends,

in the riḡván message 156 b.e. reference is made to the convocation of the first convention to form a National Spiritual Assembly in macedonia.

we have been asked to inform you that owing to conditions in that country the formation of the National Spiritual Assembly of macedonia.

kindly ensure that this information is released at the same time as the riḡván message and that caution is exercised so that it is not generally cir-culated in advance.

with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat

299

Riḡván Message 1999

Riḡván 156

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

dearly loved f riends,

our hearts are aglow with hope as we survey what has been accomplished

in the year preceding the fateful, final stretch toward the consummation of the four year plan. from the year's momentous beginning with the

eighth international bahá'í convention, the bahá'í world has sustained a

rising pace of activity that has significantly advanced the process of entry by troops. our community has grown appreciably, its human resources

have been richly enhanced. from projects of expansion to endeavors at con-

solidation, from social and economic development to external affairs, from

services of the youth to expressions in the arts, from the world center of

the faith to remote villages and towns—in fact, from whatever angle the

community is viewed—progress has been made. The prospects for the plan

are impelling.^{298.1}

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667The momentum generated at the international convention pervaded the counselors' conference that immediately followed it, further galvanizing the indefatigable participants; and it charged the proceedings of the National conventions held in May, including those of Sabah, Sarawak, and Slovakia which met for the first time to form their National Spiritual Assemblies. That same energy infused the international Teaching center, which has been displaying a remarkable potency in the short time since its sixth term began on the anniversary of the declaration of the Báb. Concentrating on refining and consolidating their organization, the counselor members have refrained from their usual travels during this first year, but they can be expected after this to resume their visits to various parts of the world, so as to reinforce their vitalizing influence on the successful conclusion of the four year plan. Further to these happenings in the Holy Land, the construction projects on Mount Carmel, beheld with such thrilling astonishment by the delegates to the international convention, press onward towards their scheduled completion at the end of the century. With the opening since last Rishván of all remaining areas of construction, the speed of work has reached a new peak. The center for the Study of the Texts and the extension to the Archives building are being readied for occupancy within a few weeks; the exterior of the international Teaching center building is fully clad in marble, while finishing work at all levels of its interior is proceeding. The lowering of Hatzionut Avenue, to accommodate the bridge which now connects the Terraces of the Shrine of the Báb on both sides of the road, has been completed and normal traffic restored. The unfolding magnificence of the Terraces has so captured public attention that the nineteenth terrace at the top of the mountain has already been opened to visitors on a daily schedule, evoking the enthusiastic response of a grateful populace. As part of a campaign to attract international attention to the city, the municipality of Haifa has published a pictorial brochure on the Shrine of the Báb and the Terraces, available in five major languages besides Hebrew. We feel compelled to mention at least two other developments at the world center of a wholly different order: first, the decision to raise the number of pilgrims in each group to 150 from 100—this to take effect when the revamping, now in progress, of the newly acquired building, situ-

ated across the way from the resting place of the greatest holy leaf, has been completed and use can be made of its provision of a pilgrim hall and other facilities for the administration of an expanded pilgrimage program. 299.2

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

668Second is the notable headway being made, despite the inevitable slowness

of the process, in the plan to translate texts from the writings of bahá'u'lláh

with a view to publishing a new english volume of his works. effort is

being devoted to providing full versions of such major Tablets as the Súriy-i-mulúk and the Súriy-i-h aykal, as well as complete texts of Tablets ad-

dressed to individual kings and rulers. Also scheduled for inclusion are the

Súriy-i-ra'ís, the lawṢ-i-ra'ís and the lawṢ-i-f u'ád.

The cause of bahá'u'lláh marches on resistlessly, quickened by the in-

creasing application of an approach to the development and use of human

resources that is systematic. The further creation of national and regional

training institutes, now numbering 344, has pressed this development

forward, with the result that, apart from North America and iran where

numerous courses have been given, some 70,000 individuals have already

completed at least one institute course. All of this is contributing to a grow-

ing body of confirmed, active supporters of the cause. The untold potential

of this progression is illustrated in such reports as the one received from chad, where in an area served by an institute more than 1,000 people em-

braced the faith through the individual efforts of those who had received

training. understanding of the necessity for systematization in the develop-

ment of human resources is everywhere taking hold.

collateral with the demonstrated efficacy of training institutes is the prag-

matic emergence of regional bahá'í councils in selected countries where

conditions have made the establishment of these institutions necessary and

viable. where there is close interaction between a council and a training

institute, the stage is set for a galvanic coherence of the processes effecting expansion and consolidation in a region, and for the practical matching of the training services of institutes to the developmental needs of local com-munities. moreover, the operational guidelines whereby the continental

counselors and the regional councils have direct access to each other give

rise to a further institutional relationship which, along with that connecting the councils to the National and local Spiritual Assemblies, effectuates a dynamic integration of functions at the regional level.

The ever-expanding work in social and economic development is also benefiting from the operation of those training institutes that give attention to such subjects as literacy, primary health care and the advancement of women. The more widespread efforts of the office of Social and economic development to promote a global process of learning about relevant bahá'í principles are enhanced by the work of these institutes, as well as by the rise

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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

669of bahá'í-inspired organizations scattered throughout the planet. clearly, then, the institutional capacity to administer development programs is gaining in strength. This is apparent in projects sponsored by bahá'í institutions or initiated by individuals through the inspiration of the faith. An outstanding example of the latter is unity college, which was created by a family in ethiopia as the first, and since late 1998, the only private college in the country, with a student body that swelled to 5,000 during this past year. Another example, on a smaller scale but of significance nonetheless, is the initiative taken by a family in buffalo, New york: here, in their home, they have been assisting tens of children and youth from the inner city to develop, through bahá'í spiritual and moral teachings, patterns of behavior that will enable them to overcome self-destructive attitudes bred by poverty and racism.

in the area of external affairs, the most energetic actions have been prompted by two tragic happenings in iran. The sudden execution in mashhad last july of mr. rúřu'lláh rawřání, the first such official action in six years, registered a shock that provoked a worldwide and unprecedented outcry by governments and u nited Nations agencies. i n late September the government's intelligence agency launched an organized attack on the bahá'í institute of higher education, involving the arrest of 36 members of the faculty and raids on more than 500 homes across the country. The latter incident inspired a global campaign of protest, still in progress, in which

academic institutions and associations, educators, and student groups have been participating, and in which the press has taken a special interest, as reflected in the appearance of substantial articles in *Le Monde*, *The New York Times* and other major newspapers. The successful passage in the United Nations General Assembly last December of yet another resolution on Iran, in which the Bahá'ís are distinctly mentioned, must surely have been influenced by these two conspicuous manifestations of an unrelenting religious persecution.

but intensive as has been the demand upon the friends in all parts of the world to defend our beleaguered brethren, much attention was devoted as well to a wide range of external affairs endeavors. The four-month-long mission undertaken by an emissary of the House of Justice, Mr. Giovanni Ballerio, to islands of the Pacific Ocean where he met with 22 heads of state, 5 heads of government and more than 40 other high-ranking officials; the efforts pursued by a number of National Assemblies, at the urging of the Bahá'í International Community's United Nations office, to promote

299.9

message from The Universal House of Justice

670 human rights education; the participation, by invitation, of representatives of South Africa's Bahá'í community in the proceedings of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, at which they were able to recount their record of unflinching support of racial unity throughout the years of apartheid; the recent success of communities in Australia, Brazil, Finland and Portugal in obtaining the decision of educational authorities to include courses on the Bahá'í faith in the curricula of primary and secondary schools—these, not to mention the public information projects that generated publicity through all forms of the media, are examples of the broadly based enterprises in external affairs that engaged the energies of the community.

A corollary spate of activities involved the use of the arts, of which the musical and other artistic performances associated with the celebration in Paris of the centenary of the establishment of the faith in Europe were an outstanding instance. The voices of Bahá'í choir, composed of 68 members drawn from Europe and the Americas, delighted audiences in eight European cities and introduced the faith to many. "Light and Fire," the completed part of an opera/ballet being written by Bahá'í composer Lasse Thoresen of

Norway, was successfully performed last September at the prestigious music festival in Poland known as the Warsaw Autumn, which was opened by the queen of Sweden. The work is based on recent heroic acts of the martyrs in Iran, a fact that exposed the audience to knowledge of the faith. Europe's apparent lead in these particular endeavors was also marked by the occasion of the Austrian chamber music festival when the Austrian cross for Sciences and Arts, the highest award of its kind for Austria, was presented by the president of the republic to Mr. Bijan Khadem-Missagh, a Bahá'í violinist and conductor. A program at that same festival featured the recitation of extracts from Bahá'í and other sacred scriptures. But a word, too, must be said in recognition of the prominent part being played by youth all over the world in their employment of the arts in the teaching work; renditions by their dance workshops, in particular, have acquired renown within and outside the Bahá'í community.

We therefore enter this Ríḫvān season, as a community in a dynamic state of transformation, enjoying a coherence of vision and activity consonant with the aim of advancing the process of entry by troops. And we begin the final year of the plan with a boost in administrative strength, as three

countries in Europe—Latvia, Lithuania and Macedonia—convoke their first conventions to form National Spiritual Assemblies and thus raise the

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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

671 festive moment is a chronology of expectations that lists, first and foremost, the conclusion of the four year plan at Ríḫvān 2000. This will be followed by the commencement on the day of the covenant of that very year of a new term of office for the continental boards of counselors, whose members will soon thereafter be called to the Bahá'í world center for a conference at which, among other matters, the features of the next global teaching and consolidation plan will be discussed. The counselors' conference will mark the occupation by the international Teaching center of its permanent seat, an occasion for which Auxiliary board members throughout the world will be invited to join the counselors in the holy land. The Mount Carmel projects will have been completed by this time and the preparations will have been well advanced for dedicatory events, scheduled to take place on 22 and 23 May 2001, to which a number of representatives from each

national bahá'í community will be invited. The details concerning these events are to be announced in due course.

This projection of portentous happenings cuts across the divide in time between the twentieth century and the new millennium, according to the reckoning of the common era. it is a projection that underscores the contrast between the confident vision that propels the constructive endeavors of an illumined community and the tangled fears seizing the millions upon millions who are as yet unaware of the day in which they are living. bereft

of authentic guidance, they dwell on the horrors of the century, despairing over what these could imply for the future, hardly appreciating that this very century contains a light that will be shed on centuries to come. ill-equipped

to interpret the social commotion at play throughout the planet, they listen to the pundits of error and sink deeper into a slough of despond. Troubled by forecasts of doom, they do battle with the phantoms of a wrongly in-formed imagination. knowing nothing of the transformative vision vouch-

safed by the lord of the Age, they stumble ahead, blind to the peerlessness of the new day of god.

The pitiful conditions implied by such a state of heart and mind cannot but prompt us all to action, unabating action, to fulfill the intentions of a plan whose major aim is to accelerate that process which will make it possible for growing numbers of the world's people to find the object of their quest and thus to build a united, peaceful and prosperous life.

dear friends: The days pass swiftly as the twinkle of a star. make your mark now, at this crucial turning point of a juncture, the like of which shall never return. make that mark in deeds that will ensure for you cele-

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message from The universal house of justice

672tial blessings—guarantee for you, for the entire race, a future beyond any earthly reckoning.

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Message to the First National Convention
of the Bahá'ís of Latvia

Ridván 156

To the bahá'ís of latvia

dear b ahá'í f riends,

it is with profound happiness that we greet the dear friends who are gathered for the first National convention of the bahá'ís of latvia. This significant achievement is the fruit of the united efforts of all the friends in the baltic States, together with the assistance of the many dedicated souls who have visited your country, beginning with miss martha root, who first brought the light of bahá'u'lláh's revelation to latvia during her visit to riga in April 1927 . Today, your community has acquired the strength to elect its own National Spiritual Assembly, and stands ready to carry forward the noble work of the cause.

dear friends, the task before you is indeed challenging. yours is the duty to show forth, by your words and by your deeds, the power of the word of god to transform human character and the ordering of society. you must strive, by the force of your example of harmony and of love towards all people, to play your part in obliterating the racial, religious and political animosities which have for so long plagued humankind. your countrymen are eagerly receptive to the gift which you can offer them, and opportunities for advancing the cause have never been so plentiful. your National Assembly, as a divinely ordained institution of the Administrative order, is the channel for the outpouring of heavenly guidance and assistance, and your faithful and loving allegiance to it will be the surest means for the attainment of your highest aspirations.

be assured that we shall offer ardent prayers in the holy Shrines that the believers in your dear country will put forth a great effort in their love for bahá'u'lláh. m ay h e bless and guide your every step.

with loving b ahá'í greetings,

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1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

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Message to the First National Convention

of the Bahá'ís of Lithuania

Ridván 156

To the b ahá'ís of lithuania

dear b ahá'í f riends,

it is with exceeding gladness that we greet the dear friends of lithuania on the historic occasion of their first National bahá'í convention. The emergence of the independent National Spiritual Assembly of the bahá'ís of lithuania is a cause of rejoicing for the whole bahá'í world. This precious victory for the cause of bahá'u'lláh is the fruit of the self-sacrificing endeavors of the devoted believers, whether native lithuanians, pioneers or traveling teachers, who have raised up a dynamic national bahá'í community where, just a decade ago, there were only two believers in the entire country. looking even further back, we can see the foundations of this achievement in the travels of miss martha root, who planted the seeds of bahá'u'lláh's Teachings in her visit to kaunas in April 1927 .

A new chapter in the history of the faith in your country is opening. you can render no greater service to your people than sharing the life-giving message of bahá'u'lláh with your fellow citizens. it is your high privilege to work toward the fulfillment of such a noble goal with ever greater vigor, confidence and courage. The continued expansion of teaching activities, the steady multiplication and consolidation of your local Spiritual Assemblies, the encouragement of youth, the holding of regular classes for children, and the ever more effective use of your training institute—these stand out among your major tasks as you face a challenging future.

for outward developments to properly endure and flourish, they must be matched by inner spiritual growth. The process of drawing ever closer to bahá'u'lláh in prayer and meditation, of deepening your grasp and appreciation of the fundamental verities of our faith, of transforming your personal lives and conduct and fostering strong bonds of unity and love among the believers will enable you to reach unimagined heights and lay the foundation for a rich and active community life which, by its example, will draw the souls of others to its blissful shelter.

rest assured that we shall pray ardently in the holy Shrines that bahá'u'lláh may bless and strengthen you with his divine confirmations 301.1

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67and enable you to foster the sound growth and development of his faith
in your land.

with loving b a h á ' í greetings,

302

Primary Source Material at the Bahá'í World Center

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]